

UNDERSTANDING CODEPENDENT BEHAVIORS

GOALS OF THE EXERCISE

1. Implement a plan for recovery from addiction that reduces the impact of adult-child-of-an-alcoholic (ACOA) traits on sobriety.
2. Decrease dependence on relationships while beginning to meet his/her own needs, build confidence, and practice assertiveness.
3. Reduce the frequency of behaviors exclusively designed to please others.
4. Begin to choose partners and friends who are responsible, respectful, and reliable.

ADDITIONAL HOMEWORK THAT CAN BE APPLICABLE TO CLIENTS WHO EXPERIENCE ACOA TRAITS

- Am I Teaching My Children Addictive Patterns?
- Building My Support Network
- Correcting Distorted Thinking
- Corresponding with My Childhood Self
- Forming Stable Relationships
- How Far Have I Come?
- Setting and Maintaining Boundaries
- Understanding Family History
- Using Books and Other Media Resources
- Using My Support Network
- What Did I Want to Be When I Grew Up?
- What Do I Want for My Children?
- What's Happening in My Early Recovery?

ADDITIONAL PROBLEMS FOR WHICH THIS EXERCISE MAY BE USEFUL

- Borderline Traits
- Dependent Traits
- Oppositional Defiant Behavior
- Partner Relationship Conflict
- Sexual Promiscuity

SUGGESTIONS FOR PROCESSING THIS EXERCISE WITH THE CLIENT

The “Understanding Codependent Behaviors” activity is intended for the client whose recovery is complicated by current codependent relationships or by a history of repeated enmeshment, rescuing, and boundary issues. This activity teaches the client about relationship addiction and the characteristics of such relationships, then heightens motivation by focusing on the risk to recovery that such situations present. It ends by offering hope and directing the client back to the therapist for guidance in working on issues of codependency. Follow-up may include discussing this issue with the therapist, group, and program sponsor; referral to CoDependents Anonymous; bibliotherapy; and videotherapy, with viewing and discussion of films such as *When a Man Loves a Woman* or others that are recommended in the book *Rent Two Films and Let's Talk in the Morning* by John W. Hesley and Jan G. Hesley, also published by John Wiley & Sons.

UNDERSTANDING CODEPENDENT BEHAVIORS

Codependency means “addiction to a person or a relationship.” A codependent person works so hard to control and fix someone else that his/her own life is in turmoil as a result. Because no one can really control anyone else, and others’ troubles are mostly due to patterns only they can change, a codependent person is in for one painful disappointment after another.

1. There are reasons we get drawn into codependent or addictive relationships, in which we try harder to straighten others out than they themselves are trying. Have you ever been addicted to relationships with dysfunctional partners? If so, was it for any of these reasons?
 - ☐ You felt needed.
 - ☐ It was intense and exciting from the start.
 - ☐ You just naturally felt drawn to them.
 - ☐ They made you feel strong, smart, and capable.
 - ☐ The sex was incredible.
 - ☐ You identified with the hardships they’d suffered—your heart ached for them.
 - ☐ You felt that you could help them and change their lives.
2. If you have gotten into relationships for these reasons, how have they usually turned out?

3. In codependent relationships, people use each other to try to feel the way they want to feel—just as they would use drugs. The telltale signs of this are clear. Here are signs of an addictive or codependent relationship. Again, please check off any that apply in your own experience:
 - ☐ Manipulation and mind games take up a lot of time and energy.
 - ☐ You’re often worried that the relationship will fall apart, so you walk on eggshells.
 - ☐ You keep your partner away from your other friends and family because they don’t get along, or you don’t think they would.
 - ☐ One of you spends a lot of time rescuing the other from problems, again and again.
 - ☐ You work hard to impress each other and keep secrets about yourselves, because you each fear that the other would reject you if he/she knew about some parts of your life or past.
 - ☐ You get in heated arguments that don’t make sense to either of you.

- _____ The relationship became very intense very fast when you first got together.
- _____ One or both of you feel a lot of jealousy and insecurity about the relationship.
- _____ The relationship is never boring, but it's usually stressful.
- _____ You go back and forth between feeling abandoned and feeling smothered.

4. Again, if you have gotten into this type of relationship, how has it usually turned out?

5. Looking over the items you checked off for question 3, does this sound like a stressful situation? _____ There is a strong connection between stress and relapse. When you started drinking, using, or doing other addictive things, was stress relief one of your reasons? Do you think a stressful relationship could make you more prone to relapse? _____ How do you feel about this risk?

6. Most people who get into codependent relationships don't just do so once. Each of us has a pattern, a type of person we find most attractive and feel most at home with. If we grew up around the type of relationships described previously, those kinds of partners are the ones we're most drawn to and most likely to attract. Have you ever met someone with whom you shared a strong magnetic attraction? _____ Describe that situation and what happened in the relationship over time:

7. Now that we've identified and studied this problem, what can you do about it?

8. There are many resources to help people avoid codependent relationships or change them into healthy ones. What have you already seen or heard of any of these resources?

9. Once you've identified the problem and figured out what you want to do, you don't have to work on it alone. What goals would you set for working on this in therapy?

How will changing your relationship patterns affect your chances of staying clean, sober, and happy?

Be sure to bring this handout back to your next session with your therapist, and be prepared to talk about your thoughts and feelings about the exercise.